

Sony Ericsson slashes jobs

Sony Ericsson, the number 4 global handset maker after Nokia, Samsung and LG, today said it would slash 2,000 more jobs after it posted a \$387 million loss in the first quarter

Hot Touch Pro

Guy in New Mexico has narrow escape as original HTC Touch Pro's battery sets his pants afire

Mobile Phone Test

Executive material Business phones Up to Rs. 25,000

Nokia E71

A beautiful looking handset that has really been built to last, the Nokia E71 is a slim, wide phone with a full-QWERTY keypad. One look and its corporate orientation is obvious. The shiny chrome rimmed front fascia and the dimpled steel battery cover all add a touch of suave sophistication. The screen could have been slightly larger but then the phone would become wider. The glossy finish feels better than the slightly matte finish on the E75. The keypad is small, and cramped; without the excellent bevelling on the keys, it would be unusable. But thanks to that and some great key feedback the keypad grows on you after a few hours of use. The menu buttons are very close to each other but well laid out and we never experienced false key hits. The call buttons are suitably larger and easy to use. The joypad is similar to the E75 but feels a little more usable mainly because the edges of the four-way scroll are not as sharp as the one on the E75. The display is crisp, with excellent colours, but we feel Nokia made the icons a little too drab. The Symbian interface has changed little for the E-Series devices but we found the menus a bit different - stuff had been moved around under different menus and there were a couple of extra options available. Corporate users will want to note that Nokia's push mail service works as well as Blackberry's and for those who feel that RIM devices are the only ones with flawless push mail service, think again. But it's the small keypad with the excellent bevelling that is the main feature of this device and once you get the hang of it, typing out long emails is no problem. Unfortunately it's not



Nokia E71



suited to quickly type out numbers to dial since the number keys are in the middle of the QWERTY keypad, and their lettering aside, not differentiated in any way.

The camera is decent, on par with the unit on the E75. The handsfree jack is a 2.5-mm unit and sadly Nokia missed a spot here as we feel all jacks should be 3.5-mm for maximum compatibility. Call

quality is good but the loudspeaker is not very loud, that being said it's louder than the unit on the E75. A couple of the X-Series phones have better call quality and therefore better in-built antennas. The handsfree unit is not as good as the one on the E75 or the N95 8 GB.

Music quality is good and the screen is good enough to view videos.

Priced at Rs. 22,949 the Nokia E71 has a great keypad and is one of the best built Nokias around. We heartily recommend it for those looking for a great multipurpose phone with strong business accents.

Blackberry Pearl Flip

The Pearl Flip is a novel looking handset. It's a clamshell design and Blackberry worked on the mechanism to give it a slightly different look with a chrome lump on the top of the device serving as a rather large hinge for the clamshell. Build quality is good over the front of the phone but the battery cover is plasticity and gets loose quickly.



Blackberry Pearl Flip

Other than that we like the design of the phone itself - it looks neat and the clamshell mechanism itself is intricately designed and eye catching. It has a decent screen and a pseudo-QWERTY keypad where a single key is shared by two alphabets. The outer screen is useful for displaying status messages and such, and can be configured to display different information. By default, this area shows a large analogue clock. For a clamshell, the Pearl Flip looks a little large but not overly so. The famous Blackberry trackball (which is how the phones get their name as its typically white and when lit up looks like a pearl) is also present and makes navigation a snap. The keypad is well laid out but it's more suited for typing numbers than long messages and mails. It is not as good as a full QWERTY. The keys themselves are flush with the body and exude decent feedback; some amount of bevelling on the top would have made things easier.

The Pearl Flip has a decent antenna that offers good clarity on-call but it's not as good as some of the Nokia phones. We like the audio quality of the handsfree unit, both on call as well as for music, although to be honest there are better options around.

A plus is the 3.5-mm interface meaning your headphones can also be used.

Priced at Rs. 21,990 the Pearl Flip seems more like a fun phone than a serious Blackberry device and this will cause many to overlook it. People who want Blackberry's usually want a full keypad since they're typically using their handset to send at least 25 mails a day. The Flip is not as usable as the other Blackberrys in this regard and we're suggesting you give it a wide berth as well.

ASUS P552w

ASUS' entry-level PDA, after the uber-cheap P320 and frankly we're not impressed. Build quality is good and the device has a nice choice of colours, although the rubberised finish may not be liked by all. Once your eyes see the display that is all you can think about - blurry, with poor font visibility really spoils it for us. It's not clear, not bright, and the text itself



ASUS P552w

is not as visible as with any of the other phones. The large chrome joypad may not be liked by all and is an eyesore in our opinion. The call buttons are cleanly laid out and easily distinguished from the others. The quick launch button next to the call accept button is a plus as most of the common options are available in a simple and intuitive menu system - in fact this is a real plus for someone not used to Window Mobile's deep and sometimes confusing menu structure. We really liked this feature and kudos to ASUS to think of it. The hold button on the side and the power button on the top are the same colour as the phone body and hardly delineated making finding them (the power button at least) a hassle. The stylus is an excellent matte finished fibre and unlike the other metal styluses with plastic tips this one is not prone to breaking if it falls.

The P552w also has a poor antenna that gives very mediocre results in our call and signal strength tests. Even the handsfree unit isn't very good and the camera seems an afterthought. At Rs. 18,990 or any other price point we reckon this phone is best given a wide berth.